A CONGRESS REVIVAL?

The party is thrilled with the timing of Sharmila's entry, at a time when rising anti-incumbency could dent the YSRCP's prospects. "This is a turnaround moment...the starting point of a Congress comeback in Andhra Pradesh," says state in-charge Manickam Tagore. A. Revanth Reddy, a relative newcomer, had been inducted as Congress president in Telangana when Tagore was in charge there, and he managed to successfully steer an electoral triumph for the party in the assembly election in December.

But while Sharmila is ambitious and industrious, she is not as aggressive as Revanth is in Telangana. Despite the acrimony, the siblings have also not spoken against each other in public. Some even paint her as a desperate politician out for revenge after being sidelined by her brother. Asked why she chose to join the Congress, she tells you, "Given that I am a minority (the YSR family follows the Christian faith), the violence in Manipur rattled me. The Congress unites all communities and is the most secular party in the country. My father's dream was to see Rahul [Gandhi] as PM, we will work for it." For the record, Sharmila has merged her two-year-old YSR Telangana Party with the Congress.

But the political terrain in Andhra Pradesh is vastly different from that in Telangana. The YSRCP, despite the desertions, is a formidable force and Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party (TDP), is a keen rival. But, as E. Venkatesu of the department of political science, University of Hyderabad, points out, "If Sharmila betters the vote share of the Congress, as is likely, it will prove costly for the YSRCP." Others are not so sure. "Sharmila may have some impact as a Congress leader in Andhra Pradesh," says Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches political science at the NALSAR University in Hyderabad, "but it will depend on some coordinated effort by the party, which is not in good shape in the state."

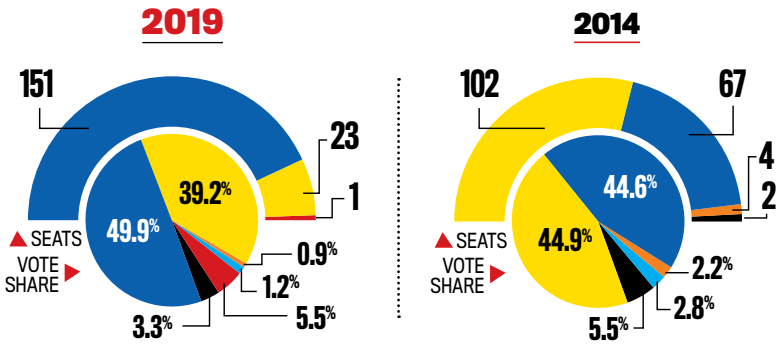


PEOPLE POWER
CM Jagan Reddy at a cyclone relief camp in Prakasam district, Dec. 3, 2023

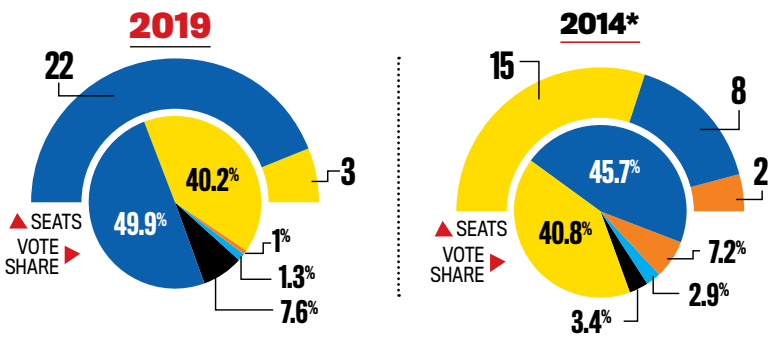
SWEEPING CHANGES

Andhra's bifurcation had a direct bearing on Congress fortunes after 2014. Jagan's loss that year after polling near-same numbers was also striking

ASSEMBLY POLLS: Total seats **175**



LOK SABHA POLLS: Total seats **25**



YSRCP TDP BJP INC JSP IND+ Others

All percentages have been rounded off; *last general election of united AP